

The Boston Globe

Serving our community since 1872

WEDNESDAY, JULY 23, 2025

House in recess; GOP in turmoil

Fallout over Epstein sex case sidetracks votes

By Annie Karni and Michael Gold

NEW YORK TIMES

WASHINGTON — Speaker Mike Johnson announced on Tuesday that he was cutting short the week's legislative business and sending the House home early for the summer on Wednesday to avoid having to hold votes on releasing files related to the accused sex trafficker Jeffrey Epstein.

Johnson's move will, for now, deny Democrats — and some Republicans — the chance to force procedural votes that would call on the Justice Department to make the information public. It reflected how deep divisions among Republicans on the matter have paralyzed the House, where GOP leaders are trying to avoid another politically perilous vote on an issue that is confounding President Trump and roiling the MAGA base.

"We're done being lectured on transparency," Johnson said at a news conference, where the typically unflappable speaker appeared frustrated.

The speaker's stance did little to alleviate the intra-party turmoil unfolding on Capitol Hill as many of Trump's supporters de-

TRUMP, Page A6

The board of Market Basket fired two top lieutenants of sidelined chief executive Arthur T. Demoulas in the latest salvo of the family feud besetting the New England institution. **B5.**

GBH announced the public station would lay off 13 employees from its PBS history program, "American Experience." **B5.**



GETTY IMAGES 2011

Ozzy Osbourne dies at 76

The Black Sabbath front-man helped usher in heavy metal rock before he found TV fame as a befuddled father. **C9.**



Bark at the sun

Wednesday: Sun, a few clouds. High 78-83, low 66-71.

Thursday: Heat is back on. High 90-95, low 70-75.

High tide: 10:40, 10:50.

Sunrise: 5:28. Sunset: 8:13.

Weather and comics, **G6-7.** Obituaries, **C9.**

VOL. 308, NO. 23

*

Suggested retail price
\$4.00



Fire probe zeroes in on smoking

Fall River investigators determine where fatal blaze began

By Spencer Buell and Christopher Gavin

GLOBE STAFF

and Ava Berger

GLOBE CORRESPONDENT

FALL RIVER — Investigators may never know for certain what sparked the fire here, on the left side of the U-shaped as-

sisted living facility.

But as they sifted through the charred and waterlogged remains of a room on the second floor of Gabriel House for clues, they ruled out some possible culprits and discovered evidence of what officials say could have been a hazardous mix:

medical oxygen and smoking.

A scooter, damaged in the fire, was not to blame, they said. It wasn't a faulty stove or electrical outlet, nor was it a candle or stick of incense, they said.

But they zeroed in on "numerous smoking materials"

found in the room where investigators said the fire started, as well as an oxygen concentrator, a medical device that increases the amount of oxygen in the air a patient breathes and can fuel flames when exposed to embers.

They can't ask the person who lived there, whom they didn't identify, what happened. The room's resident, along with

nine others from Gabriel House, perished.

More than a week after the deadly July 13 fire, which also sent more than 30 people to area hospitals, a clearer picture of what happened that night has begun to come into focus.

Also becoming clearer are plans designed to keep similar disasters from happening else-

FIRE, Page A10

DESPERATE FOR FOOD



JEHAD ALSHRAFI/ASSOCIATED PRESS

Palestinians held onto an aid truck returning to Gaza City from the northern Gaza Strip on Tuesday. The UN's human rights office said more than 1,000 Palestinians have been killed by Israeli forces since May while trying to get food in the Gaza Strip. Also on Tuesday, the World Health Organization said Israeli troops attacked two of its sites in central Gaza Strip. **A4.**

'We have great concerns for public safety.'

MARC TOHME, Suffolk assistant district attorney

Judge dismisses 102 cases amid lawyer work stoppage

Charges range from shoplifting to assault and drug trafficking

By Sean Cotter

GLOBE STAFF

Defendant after defendant on Tuesday heard the same message from Boston Municipal Court Chief Justice Tracy-Lee Lyons: "This case shall be dismissed without prejudice today."

All told, 102 people who had been charged with a range of crimes, from the petty to the violent, saw their cases dropped because the government had been unable to provide them a lawyer.

Tuesday's hearing marked a remark-

able step underscoring the ongoing crisis created by a work stoppage by the private court-appointed attorneys known as bar advocates, who represent most of the state's indigent defendants who otherwise can't afford lawyers. The charges, read out in quick succession by court clerks, spanned from shoplifting and driving on a suspended license to domestic violence, assault and battery with a dangerous weapon, and drug trafficking.

"We have great concerns for public safety," Suffolk Assistant District Attorney Marc Tohme, chief of district court prosecutions, told the court. "It's clearly a frustrating and sad day for the Commonwealth."

DISMISSALS, Page A10

Healey, some Democrats at odds over lending firm

AG's plan targets nonprofit accused of predatory practices

By Samantha J. Gross

GLOBE STAFF

Last year, Governor Maura Healey dismayed advocates when she signed into law protections for a Boston nonprofit that has been battling accusations of predatory lending for years. Now her Democratic colleague down the hall is proposing sweeping regulatory changes that would clamp down on BlueHub Capital.

The regulations, outlined in an eight-page proposal published by state Attorney General Andrea Campbell's office earlier this month, put the state's top prosecutor at odds with Healey, her predecessor, who last year signed a bill that

exempts BlueHub from the state's consumer protection laws.

Many of Campbell's proposals also appear in a bill filed by state Representative Michelle Dubois, a Brockton Democrat whose district is home to dozens of families who participated in the BlueHub program at the center of ongoing litigation.

Under a program the nonprofit calls BlueHub SUN, BlueHub buys properties from banks that are foreclosing on the homeowners, then resells them to the original owners.

As part of the deal, the homeowners take on what is known as a shared appreciation mortgage — a relatively rare type of real estate loan that entitles BlueHub to a portion of any increase in the home's value when the homeowner sells or refinances the property.

In a statement, BlueHub spokesperson-

BLUE HUB, Page A7

For those buried in student loan debt, Trump's tax law expected to deepen hole

By Mara Kardas-Nelson

GLOBE STAFF

Emiliana German Roman was too young to vote when she took out her first student loan. She was 17, a first-generation Dominican American and a first-generation college student.

She worked her way through college and earned two scholarships, picking away at her school's \$70,000 tuition. In 2022, she graduated cum

laude from Stonehill College in Easton with a bachelor's degree in criminology, sociology, and speech-language pathology — and more than \$20,000 in federal student loan debt.

Now program coordinator for the City of Boston's office of food justice, 25-year-old German Roman feels the weight of that debt every day.

"I'm at an age when people are advancing in their careers, starting families, buying houses," she said. "[The debt] takes

a huge emotional and financial toll. I'm very pro-active, I create budgets. On every spreadsheet, I have to budget for this dark cloud."

German Roman is one of the nearly 43 million Americans who collectively hold more than \$1.7 trillion in student loan debt, 90 percent of which is federal loans. That debt disproportionately affects people of color and women, weighing on their career pros-

LOANS, Page A7



BARRY CHIN/GLOBE STAFF

Emiliana German Roman graduated with more than \$20,000 in debt. "I create budgets. On every spreadsheet, I have to budget for this dark cloud," she said.